

1450–1500

THE FASHION SPLIT

By the middle of the 15th century there were marked regional differences in women's dress. The medieval standard one-piece tunic moved towards a broad spectrum of fashions in cut and construction. As garments began to separate into pieces, dressmaking played with the cut of skirts and sleeves newly liberated from bodices, and incorporated folded collars and laced closures. Headwear continued trends from earlier in the century but was becoming spectacularly complex. As the elongated Gothic look disappeared, clothing became softer and wider. Improved weaving technologies continued to increase textile production and make fabrics more affordable, especially for the growing, prosperous merchant classes. In Northern Europe fur remained a vital addition for warmth.

HATS AND VEILS



High forehead



Cylindrical hat

Headdresses often emphasized a woman's high, smooth forehead. Many women bleached their hair to a fashionable blonde, or plucked their hairline to create a higher forehead. Cylindrical hats of different lengths were stylish in France, Burgundy, England, and the Low Countries. They were supported by a small cap or wire structure. Wiring and pins were used to attach fine veils of silk or linen over the headdress.

Double cornet headdress The padded roll on this French lady's headdress creates a split effect like a clamshell. Her ballgown shows the shift from a high *houppelande* neckline to the lower V-line one, with less pleating. She could wear another gown over this one.

Wulsthaube (German headgear) made of decorative cloth over a large linen roll in fashionable turban shape

End of linen veil

Pleating

Lacing shows linen shift underneath

Cuffs extending over hands

Shift shows through open sleeve seam with buttons

Structured support holds up padded roll

Full, circular skirt attached at waist

Rounded veil Women in Germanic regions kept a more natural soft shape developed from the medieval *houppelande*. Rounded lines appeared in their hats, veils, and necklines. The central panel of pleating gave a neat fullness to the skirt.

Sleeves getting tighter

Entirely lined in white fur

Belt holds extra fabric in pleats

Streamer connects her to fellow dancer

Long trailing hem

Long hair tied back

No waistline

Silk and gold textile

Stiffened bands

Split overgown The trend for visible linen undergarments began in Spain. In this portrait from 1482 Isabel of Castile's long, white shift sleeves are pulled from a slit in her outer sleeve. Reinforced horizontal bands help the skirt to stand out – this is the farthingale's origin.